



More About The Desktop

As we've been mentioning pretty much continuously throughout this book, most Desktop programs operate in pretty much the same way. In Chapter 5 we covered the features that most Desktop programs have in common. In Chapter 6, we took an in-depth look at the Finder and covered concepts pertaining to documents, files, and folders at the same time.

Since you know about using the Desktop's elements and how to launch applications from the Finder, you know enough to use most Desktop-based programs. However, you'll get further faster if we give you a few more pointers on dialogs you'll see again and again as you use Desktop applications under System 6.

One of these dialogs is the Standard File dialog. You use a Standard File dialog when you tell an application which document you want to work with and when you save and name a document. System 6 provides Standard File dialogs to keep the user interface consistent—it's just one more way to make all programs work the same.

You'll also see standard dialogs when you print your documents. One dialog, Page Setup, allows you to tell the application what size paper you'll be using and other information the computer needs to determine how to divide your document into pages. The Print dialog appears when you actually print your document and allows you to specify the number of copies you want printed, which pages to print, and whether to use draft or letter quality print.

The other dialog we'll cover is the mini-launcher. We mentioned it in passing in the last chapter; it's a small program that appears when you quit a program and there's no previous application for the program to quit to. (In reality, it's little more than a Standard File dialog.)

Remember, these features are a part of System 6 itself and are available in all Desktop programs. Learning how to use these dialogs will make Desktop programs even easier to use.

Let's get into a program that works with documents so you can follow along in our discussion. We suggest the Teach program from the "SystemTools2" disk. (It may also be on your hard drive if you installed System 6 there.) Teach is a sort of miniature word processor that's intended for reading and creating short text documents. The Finder uses it as the default application for text files. For now, just double-click the "Teach" icon to start the program.